

Eulogy for Jo Anna (Maxwell) Parker – September 2026

Five months ago... / I was privileged to speak about the life of Billie Parker. //

I now have the sacred honor to speak for Jo Anna Maxwell Parker. //

Though I came to know her well only in the past 5 years, we were still friends of a sort; I will speak as honestly as I can about her. / In the end, Jo Anna was simply not able to articulate her hope for reconciliation and communion with you all. I now try to articulate that hope on her behalf. //

Jo Anna would expect nothing less. / She had opinions about how things should be done. //

----- 1

In April... Bill and Jo Anna were two months shy... of 69 years together. //

Bill went first. /

Jo Anna stayed... //

And now... they rest side by side. //

That seems right. // co-dependent in life, / side-by-side in death.

----- 2

Let's start at the beginning. //

Jo Anna Maxwell... //

She was the second oldest... of four children. //

And her childhood... was a hard one. //

There was chaos in the Maxwell house. Abuse. Neglect.

There were seasons... when the parents were simply... **gone**. //

And when that happened --

a girl... still a child herself... / found herself raising siblings. //

No authority.

No experience.

No one to show her how. //

She had to be a mother... / before she ever got to be a girl. / **She wasn't equipped for such things...** //

And here is the truth about a childhood like that. //

It does not stay in childhood. //

It followed her... all her life. / In her **mind**. / In her **moods**. / In her **fears**. //

When you remember Jo Anna at her most difficult... / remember where the difficulty started. //

----- 3

The Bible knows about childhoods like that. //

Psalm 27 says: “**Even if my father and mother abandoned me... the LORD would take me in.**” //

Scripture doesn’t pretend... that parents never fail. //

It says God receives... the child they failed. //

----- 4

And then... there was Bill. //

In 1957... she married that Air Force pilot. / He was 24... she was 20. //

And from that day... Jo Anna lived the life of a military wife. //

Count the moves. //

Japan... in 1960 -- with a nine-month-old baby... Steve. /

Houston... where David was born. /

Alabama. /

Massachusetts -- / and the fourteen-foot snow drifts... of the Blizzard of '78. /

Florida... where Bill commanded Duke Air Base. //

And through Bill’s two tours in Vietnam --

She commanded the base at home... perhaps, not really knowing how that **ought** to be done. //

----- 5

Now -- / if you ever walked into Jo Anna’s home... / you never forgot it. //

Gold.

Bold.

Oversized. Nothing timid... anywhere in sight. //

Furniture from Japan... and Thailand. / Chaise lounges. / Fresh flowers. / Shine... on every surface. //

Some people would have called it gaudy. //

Jo Anna called it beautiful. //

And in her house... there was only one vote that counted. //

Here’s the part that made us smile. //

Her taste was extravagant. / Her wallet... was not. //

She would buy the boldest gold lamp in the store -- / but never... at full price. //

And that house was kept... fastidiously. / Every piece in its place. / Every surface polished. //

The General... ran a tight ship, as they say... //

----- 6

Her home... was built for company. //

Jo Anna loved a dinner party. //

She went looking for occasions to host them. //

Several complete sets of China. /

Serving dishes... for every type of cuisine. /

Glassware galore... //

She wanted people... to have a good time. //

She smiled a lot. /

She was generous... often quietly. **Sometimes with too much show.** /

She dressed... decoratively. / Always. //

And, as I discovered, she loved to be teased about her peculiar ways. //

----- 7

She also had standards. //

Decorum. / Proper behavior. / Things done... the right way. //

She held the rest of us to those standards... / **whether we asked... or not.** //

She would correct you... about using the wrong fork. //

The apostle Paul once wrote: **"And do everything in a decent and orderly manner."** //

Jo Anna could have written that verse. //

Though between us -- / she did not always meet her own standards. //

More on that... in a minute. //

----- 8

A life... is never just one thing. //

Jo Anna struggled... with depression. //

Her mind... was not a peaceful place.

There were dark seasons. / There were days when steadiness... **was simply out of reach.** //

And in those days... she leaned on Bill. //

Very Hard. //

Bill was there. / Most every-time. //

Do you know what he called her? //

"My precious one." //

Not when she was easy. //

When she was hard. //

That... is what *empathetic devotion* looks like. //

And then her memory began to leave her -- and she knew it was leaving. //

She suffered as a child. / *She suffered with her mind as a mother and wife.* / She suffered at the end. //

She never really realized that suffering is a uniquely human experience. That one purpose of suffering is to draw us closer to ultimate Truth, to the Good, to our Creator. The angels in heaven watch in awe as we, lowly humans, endure what only we have in common with God the Son Himself, the experience of suffering.

----- 9

Jo Anna loved going to church. // **She truly wanted to know God.** //

She loved the dressing up. / The gathering. / The occasion of it. // **She wanted understanding.** /

But if you are asking... whether Jo Anna was a model of obedience -- //

No. //

She was not. //

She loved her things... more than the Book says to.

She could be vain. / She could be sharp. / She could be demanding.

The sermon on Sunday... did not always survive to Monday. //

She was... in plain terms... a sinner. //

Which puts her... in the company of every person in this room. //

----- 10

Jo Anna suffered in Mind, Body, and Spirit. / There is no human cure for such systemic issues.

The best help that mankind can offer includes addictive prescriptions. /

Sympathy... / that helps.... //

Jo Anna sought relief for her persistent neuropathy. /

I spent most of a year, when visiting Bill and Jo Anna, trying to *convince* her that relaxing with a couple of ice-cold beers would help. // **She enjoyed the company.**

We laughed about it as she pretended to be / “almost convinced”. //

She responded in kind... / she stocked the refrigerator with cold ones so that, whenever I visited, I could show her how to administer the treatment. //

To sympathize means to keep one foot in reality while pulling someone else out of the hole they are in. Never get into the hole with them. That won’t help. //

There is only one Man that provides the cure for what ailed Jo Anna. The same one that cures what ails each of us.

Our **Great Physician** knows how to **sympathize** with us.... In the Book to the **Hebrews** we read...

“Therefore, since we have a great high priest who has passed through the heavens, Jesus the Son of God, let us hold fast to our confession. For we do not have a high priest incapable of **sympathizing** with our weaknesses, but one who has been tempted in every way just as we are, yet without sin. Therefore, let us confidently approach the throne of grace **to receive mercy and find grace whenever we need help.**” (Hebrews 4:14-16)

The question... is whether such healing grace is real. //

----- 11

Here is a picture... made for Jo Anna. //

She knew about fine dinnerware. / China. / Crystal. / Silver / Gold. //

So, listen to the Apostle Paul: //

“But we have this treasure in clay jars... so that the extraordinary power belongs to God... and does not come from us.” // (2 Corinthians 4:7)

God keeps His treasure... in breakable jars. //

Cracked ones. / Chipped ones. / Jars that never did sit level. / **Jars like Jo Anna... //**

The power was never in the jar. //

Psalm 34 says: //

“The LORD is near the brokenhearted... he delivers those who are discouraged.” //

Near... the depressed mind. //

Near... the failing memory. //

Near... the body in pain. //

Near. //

----- 12

Jesus said: //

**"Accumulate for yourselves treasures in heaven... where moth and devouring insect do not destroy...
For where your treasure is... there your heart will be also." //**

Jo Anna heard that sermon... and then went shopping anyway. //

The China... will pass to other hands. //

The gold... will sit on someone else's shelf. //

But some of what she gathered... was real treasure --

The full tables... the hopeful times... the small kindnesses to children... the quiet generosity. //

That part... keeps. //

----- 13

So, what hope... do we have for Jo Anna? //

Not the hope... that she earned her way in. / She didn't. / Nobody does. //

Listen to the parable Jesus told... about a dinner party. //

A master prepared a banquet. / The respectable guests... made excuses. //

So, the master said: //

"Go out to the highways and country roads and urge people to come in... so that my house will be filled." //

Did you hear that? //

God's table... is not set for the people who deserve a seat. //

It is set for the people... He calls in anyway. //

If heaven were only for model believers... / it would be a very small dinner party. //

The host wants the house... full. //

Jo Anna... / **of all people...** / understood a host like that. //

----- 15

And how does the Bible picture that gathering? //

Not clouds. / Not harps. //

A table. //

David wrote: **"You prepare a feast before me... my cup is completely full." //**

Isaiah prophesied: [The LORD will prepare] a **banquet** on the mountain... where God **“will swallow up death permanently”** ... and **“wipe away the tears from every face.”** //

Revelation reads: **“Blessed are those who are invited... to the banquet at the wedding celebration of the Lamb!”** //

Jesus said **“I am going away to make ready a place for you... and I will come again and take you to be with me.”** //

Making ready a place. / Preparing rooms. / Setting a table. //

Jesus is doing for Jo Anna... / what Jo Anna spent her life wanting to do... for everyone else. //

At His table... there is no depression... no nerve pain... no fading memory... no tears. //

Revelation says the main street of that city... is pure gold. //

Jo Anna will approve of these decorations. / And knowing her... she might have suggestions. //

----- 16

Paul told the Thessalonians: //

“We do not want you to be uninformed... about those who are asleep... so that you will not grieve like the rest... who have no hope.” //

The first Christians called death... sleep. //

Their word for a graveyard... meant “sleeping place.” //

Because to them... a grave was a bed... you get up from. //

So yes -- we grieve today. //

But we do not grieve... like people without hope. //

Because our hope was never... in Jo Anna’s performance. //

Our hope... is in a faithful God... / whose grace is greater than our sin. //

Jo Anna rests... as Bill rests. //

And the same God of Mercy... holds them both. //

----- 17

So, we remember Jo Anna... exactly as she was. //

Bold as gold... / and broken.

Gracious hostess....

Quick to smile... / quick to correct your table manners.

Wounded early... and carrying those wounds... a long, long way. //

Not an obedient saint. //

A woman... // **One of us... / bearing the image of her Creator... and standing in need of His grace. //**

Bill called her... “his precious one.” //

We trust... that God... in His mercy... / calls her precious too. //

And so, she rests... / within the hands of a faithful God. //

Closing Prayer

Lord God, //

We come to You... with gratitude... and humility. //

Thank You for Jo Anna --

for her welcoming generosity... her full tables...

and for every good time she orchestrated... for the people she loved. //

You know the whole story --

the sparkle... and the sharp edges...

the faith that was real... and the obedience that was not...

the childhood that wounded her... and the years that wore her down. //

We do not come pretending she earned Your favor.

None of us have. //

We come... trusting in Your mercy. //

Thank You that You stay near the brokenhearted.

Thank You that Your grace... is greater than our sin. //

Bring comfort now... to those who grieve.

Bring peace... to this family. //

Teach us to welcome one another... as You welcome us --

not because we deserve a seat... but because You want the house full. //

And we rest in Your promise --

that You have made ready a place...

and that a seat at Your table... is prepared. //

In Jesus' name, //

Amen. //

By Phillip Pennington, September 2026 – Phil@UsefulEngines.com